Marathon Training Plan: Oct 2026 – Aug 2027

Race: Saturday 28 August 2027

Rules

1. **Easy means easy.** Run easy days at 6:00–6:40 /km, or by heart rate at roughly 150 bpm or below (your data shows 147–155 at those paces). If heart rate climbs, slow down. About 80% of weekly running should be at this effort.
2. **One variable at a time.** Weekly km rises by no more than about 10%, and every fourth week is a cutback of 20–25%.
3. **Long run caps.** It grows by at most 1–2 km per week and stays at or under 40% of weekly km until the marathon block. There the 28–32 km runs reach 45–50% of the week, so they come only every other week with lighter long runs between.
4. **Hip pain rule.** Mild discomfort up to 2/10 that does not worsen during the run and is gone by the next morning is fine. Anything above 3/10, pain that changes your stride, or pain still there the next morning means stop, rest 2–3 days, and restart one week lower. If it recurs twice, see a physiotherapist.
5. **Strength twice a week.** Twenty minutes of hip and core work (section below) is part of the plan, not an extra.
6. **Rest after long runs.** The day after a long run is rest or very easy; no hard session within 48 hours.

Phases at a glance

Each phase ends with a simple check. Don't pass it on the calendar alone: if the check isn't met, repeat the previous week until it is.

Phase	Weeks / dates	Km per week	Long run	Focus	Check before moving on
Rebuild	Wk 1–8 5 Oct – 29 Nov	20 → 31	8 → 12 km	Easy running only, 3 runs a week; start strength work twice a week	3 pain-free weeks in a row
Base	Wk 9–20 30 Nov – 21 Feb	32 → 46	13 → 18 km	4 runs a week, strides, hill sprints; fartlek and steady runs from late Jan	45 km weeks feel routine and the hip stays quiet
Build	Wk 21–29 22 Feb – 25 Apr	47 → 55	18 → 21 km	One threshold or tempo session a week; half marathon race in week 28	Half marathon result sets your marathon pace
Marathon block	Wk 30–44 26 Apr – 8 Aug	50 → 66	20 → 32 km	5 runs a week, MP inside long runs; three long runs of 30–32 km	Last 32 km long run done
Taper	Wk 45–47 9 – 28 Aug	50 → 15	22 → 16 km	Volume drops, short MP pieces stay; rest, sleep, rehearse race-day kit	**Race day: Saturday 28 August 2027, 42.2 km**

Week by week

Tick the week off when done. Km and long-run figures are targets, not minimums; landing 10% under is fine. MP = goal marathon pace, set from your half marathon in week 28. Cutback weeks are shaded. Session details are in the next section.

✓	Wk	Dates	Phase	Km	Long run	Key session / notes
✓	1	5–11 Oct	Rebuild	20	8	3 easy runs (5, 7, 8 km)
☐	2	12–18 Oct	Rebuild	22	9	3 easy runs
☐	3	19–25 Oct	Rebuild	24	10	3 easy runs
☐	4	26 Oct–1 Nov	Rebuild	19	8	Cutback
☐	5	2–8 Nov	Rebuild	26	11	Add 4 × 20 s strides after one easy run
☐	6	9–15 Nov	Rebuild	28	12	Optional 4th run of 4–5 km
☐	7	16–22 Nov	Rebuild	31	12	4 runs
☐	8	23–29 Nov	Rebuild	25	10	Cutback. Gate: 3 pain-free weeks before moving on
☐	9	30 Nov–6 Dec	Base	32	13	Strides twice a week from now on
☐	10	7–13 Dec	Base	34	13	
☐	11	14–20 Dec	Base	36	14	
☐	12	21–27 Dec	Base	28	11	Cutback
☐	13	28 Dec–3 Jan	Base	37	15	Add 6 × 10 s hill sprints to one easy run
☐	14	4–10 Jan	Base	39	15	
☐	15	11–17 Jan	Base	41	16	
☐	16	18–24 Jan	Base	32	12	Cutback
☐	17	25–31 Jan	Base	43	16	Fartlek: 8 × 1 min steady / 1 min easy
☐	18	1–7 Feb	Base	45	17	Fartlek: 6 × 2 min / 1 min
☐	19	8–14 Feb	Base	46	18	Steady 20 min
☐	20	15–21 Feb	Base	37	14	Cutback
☐	21	22–28 Feb	Build	47	18	Threshold 3 × 8 min
☐	22	1–7 Mar	Build	49	19	Threshold 3 × 10 min

✓	Wk	Dates	Phase	Km	Long run	Key session / notes
☐	23	8–14 Mar	Build	51	20	Tempo 20 min
☐	24	15–21 Mar	Build	41	15	Cutback; 5 km effort test to update paces
☐	25	22–28 Mar	Build	53	20	Threshold 4 × 8 min
☐	26	29 Mar–4 Apr	Build	55	21	Tempo 25 min; last 5 km of long run at half-marathon effort
☐	27	5–11 Apr	Build	47	15	Mini-taper: 2 × 10 min threshold
☐	28	12–18 Apr	Build	42	21.1	**Half marathon race** (checkpoint, sets MP)
☐	29	19–25 Apr	Build	36	14	Recovery, easy only
☐	30	26 Apr–2 May	Marathon	50	20	Threshold 3 × 10 min
☐	31	3–9 May	Marathon	54	22	Tempo 25 min; medium-long run 14 km
☐	32	10–16 May	Marathon	57	24	Long run with last 6 km at MP
☐	33	17–23 May	Marathon	46	18	Cutback
☐	34	24–30 May	Marathon	58	25	Threshold 4 × 10 min; medium-long 15 km
☐	35	31 May–6 Jun	Marathon	60	26	Long run with 2 × 5 km at MP
☐	36	7–13 Jun	Marathon	62	28	Midweek 10 km at MP (inside a 14 km run)
☐	37	14–20 Jun	Marathon	50	20	Cutback
☐	38	21–27 Jun	Marathon	62	28	Long run with 10 km at MP in the middle
☐	39	28 Jun–4 Jul	Marathon	64	30	Easy long run; threshold 3 × 12 min midweek
☐	40	5–11 Jul	Marathon	64	26	Long run with 14 km at MP
☐	41	12–18 Jul	Marathon	52	20	Cutback
☐	42	19–25 Jul	Marathon	66	32	Easy long run; practise race fuelling
☐	43	26 Jul–1 Aug	Marathon	60	24	Long run with 16 km at MP (dress rehearsal)
☐	44	2–8 Aug	Marathon	66	32	Last long run, easy
☐	45	9–15 Aug	Taper	50	22	Long run with 8 km at MP
☐	46	16–22 Aug	Taper	38	16	2 × 3 km at MP
☐	47	23–29 Aug	Taper	15 + race	42.2	3 short easy runs with strides Mon–Thu, rest Fri; **race Saturday 28 Aug**

The week of 28 Sep – 4 Oct (now) counts as week 0: your Wednesday, Thursday and Saturday runs make about 20 km, which is exactly where week 1 starts. If any of the gaps in August and September were the hip flaring up, repeat weeks 1–2 at 3 × 5 km before progressing.

Weekly templates and sessions

Days are movable; you have done long runs on Mondays and Wednesdays before, and that is fine. Keep the order: no two hard days (long run or quality session) back to back. Since the race is on a Saturday, try to do at least the last few long runs on a Saturday morning to rehearse the routine.

Phase	Weeks	Runs	Typical week
Rebuild	1–8	3 (4 from wk 6)	Easy · rest · easy · rest · long · rest · rest
Base	9–20	4	Easy + strides · rest · easy · rest · easy + strides/fartlek · long · rest
Build	21–29	4–5	Easy · quality · rest · easy · rest · long · optional easy 5 km
Marathon	30–44	5	Easy · quality · easy · medium-long · rest · long · rest
Taper	45–47	4–5	Same shape as Marathon, shorter, with short MP pieces

Strength (next section) goes on two easy or rest days, not the day before the long run.

Session	How to run it
Easy run	6:00–6:40 /km, about 150 bpm or below, fully conversational.
Long run	Same effort as easy. Start slow; the last third may drift slightly faster. From 20 km, carry water and practise gels or sports drink.
Strides	4–6 × 20 s smooth and fast (not sprinting) on flat ground, walk back to recover. After an easy run.
Hill sprints	6–8 × 10 s hard uphill, walk down fully recovered. Builds strength with little impact.
Fartlek / steady	Comfortably hard but in control, around 5:30–5:45 /km for you today.
Threshold / tempo	"Comfortably hard": you could say a few words but not chat, roughly 160–168 bpm for you. Intervals take 2 min easy jog between. 2 km easy warm-up and cool-down.
Medium-long run	14–18 km easy, midweek, in the marathon block.
MP segments	At goal marathon pace inside a longer run. Set MP from your week-28 half: half-marathon pace + about 4–6% (for example, 5:20 /km half pace → 5:33–5:39 /km MP).
5 km effort test	Warm up 2 km, then a hard but even 5 km. Use it to sanity-check threshold pace.
Hot days	Common in the June–August marathon block. Run easy days by heart rate rather than pace, do long runs early in the morning, drink to thirst plus electrolytes on runs over 90 minutes, and let MP segments run 5–10 s/km slower when it is above about 20 °C.

Strength and hip routine

Twice a week, about 20 minutes, from week 1. Strong glutes and hip flexors share the load your hip flexor took alone during the long runs. Start with bodyweight; add a band or weight once 3 sets feel easy.

Exercise	Sets × reps	Targets
Glute bridge → single-leg bridge	3 × 12 (each leg)	Glutes, hamstrings
Standing banded knee drive (or lying straight-leg raise)	3 × 12 each side, slow lowering	Hip flexors
Side plank with top-leg lift	3 × 20–30 s each side	Hip abductors, core
Reverse lunge or split squat	3 × 10 each leg	Quads, glutes, balance
Single-leg calf raise	3 × 15 each leg	Calves, Achilles
Dead bug	3 × 10 each side	Deep core, pelvic control

After runs, a gentle kneeling hip flexor stretch (2 × 30 s per side) is fine if it feels good; skip it if it provokes the old pain.

Adjusting the plan

- **No half marathon in mid-April.** Race one in early May instead and swap it for the week-31 long run, with an easy recovery week after. If there is none, run a solo 18 km with the last 10 km at half-marathon effort and set MP from that.
- **Missed up to a week.** Carry on with the plan as written.
- **Missed 1–2 weeks.** Go back one week per missed week, then continue. Before week 30, the time comes out of Base or Build; never shorten the marathon block or the taper.
- **Missed more than 2 weeks, or illness.** Restart at about 60% of your last full week and rebuild over 2–3 weeks.
- **Hip pain returns.** Follow rule 4. If you need more than 3 days off, also drop quality sessions for the following week.
- **Feeling great.** Stay with the plan. Spare energy is better spent on strength work and sleep than extra kilometres.